

FREE SAMPLER

SECOND EDITION

6 OF 72 METHODS

Neurodiversity lens on every method

FIELD TESTED

Six facilitation methods, built to work
for **every mind in the room.**

Each one complete: an at-a-glance box, a flowchart, a neurodiversity lens, notes for running it online, and two worked examples.

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What's in this sampler

Field Tested has 72 facilitation methods. This sampler gives you six of them in full, exactly as they appear in the book, one from each of six categories. Pick one and use it in your next session.

WHAT MAKES IT DIFFERENT

Every method carries a Neurodiversity Lens: concrete moves that make it work for every mind in the room. Send it ahead, offer a spoken route wherever writing is asked for, and build in movement and quieter ways to contribute, without diluting the method.

Where the lens comes from. Twenty years in the classroom, then corporate consulting and my years at USAID, in rooms where many people were working in English as a second language. These are the moves that kept those rooms open to everyone. – Matt

Pre-mortem

p. 5

PS • Problem Solving • 45-60 min • 6-20

After Action Review

p. 12

RF • Reflection & Feedback • 30-60 min • 4-20

Brainwriting

p. 20

IG • Idea Generation • 20-45 min • 4-30

Sailboat

p. 26

GS • Goal Setting & Clarification • 45-60 min • 4-15

Nominal Group Technique (NGT)

p. 32

DM • Decision Making • 1.5-2 hr • 5-12

Six Thinking Hats

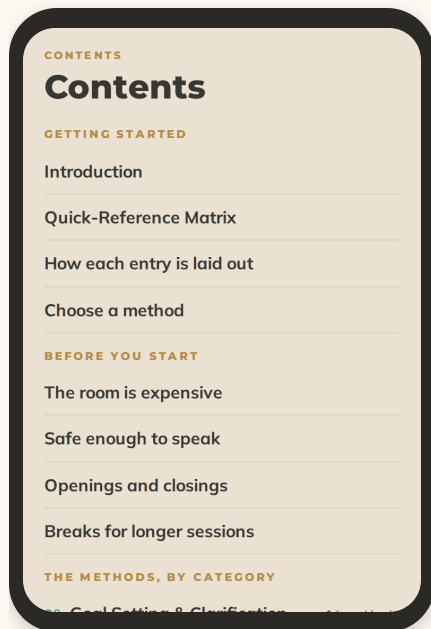
p. 37

UP • Uncovering Perspectives & Expertise • 1-2 hr • 4-12

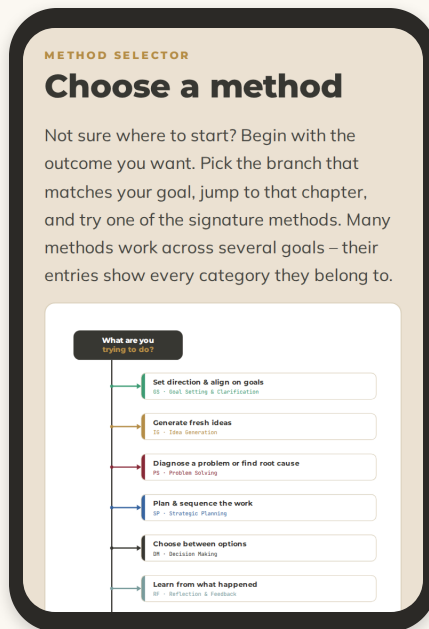
After the six methods you'll find the book's [Quick-Reference Matrix](#) (page 44), so you can see all 72 at a glance. Links to methods that aren't in this sampler go to the full guide.

How the full version works

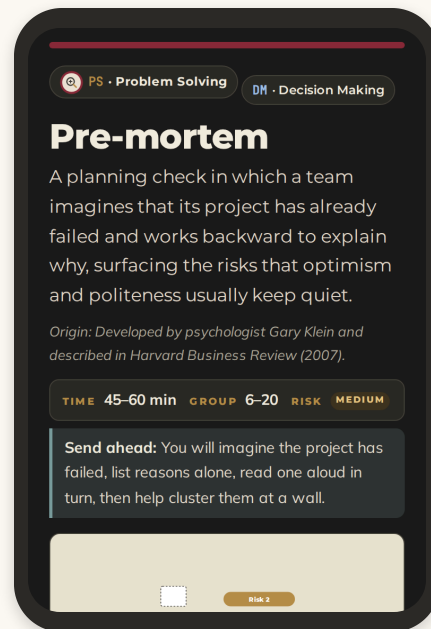
Field Tested is an EPUB ebook. It reflows to fit the screen, so it reads comfortably on a phone in the room, a tablet, a laptop or a Kindle, at whatever type size suits you. It follows your reader's dark mode too.



Find your way. The contents run from the room itself to the methods by category, then an A–Z index.



Start from your goal. Choose a method asks what you're trying to do and points you to a chapter and a few methods to start with.



Run it from your phone. Every entry has the same shape. In dark mode it's easy on the eyes in a dim room.

EVERYTHING LINKS

Category tags jump to their chapter. *Pairs well with* jumps straight to the partner method. The Quick-Reference Matrix and the A–Z index take you to any of the 72 in one tap.

OPENING IT

On a Mac, double-click and it opens in Apple Books. On iPhone and iPad, tap and share to Books. On Windows or Android, use Google Play Books or a free reader. For Kindle, use Send to Kindle. If it won't open, write to me and I'll get you a file that does.

MORE THAN METHODS

Before the methods: the science of the room and psychological safety, openers, closings and sequences, how to plan breaks for longer sessions, and the 6C Decision Compass for naming how a decision gets made.

WHO IT'S LICENSED TO

A single copy is licensed to one reader. Team licenses cover 5 or 10 readers, and an organization license covers everyone, with an optional train-the-trainer workshop.

ORIENTATION

How each entry is laid out

Every method follows the same shape so you can scan fast and find what you need under pressure. A color and icon mark each method's **category**, and an **Origin** line credits the people who created it, where there are any. A **flowchart** shows the process at a glance. The **Neurodiversity Lens** gives concrete moves to make the method work for every mind in the room. **Pairs well with** names the methods that combine well and says why. **Run it online** covers remote and hybrid rooms. Every method closes with two worked examples, **In practice · Humanitarian** and **In practice · Corporate**, so you can see it in the field and in the boardroom.

THE SEVEN CATEGORIES



GS

Goal Setting & Clarification



IG

Idea Generation



PS

Problem Solving



SP

Strategic Planning



DM

Decision Making



RF

Reflection & Feedback



UP

Uncovering Perspectives & Expertise

NEURODIVERSITY LENS

Every method has this box. It gives practical adjustments (advance notice, pacing, more than one way to contribute) that lower cognitive and social load and widen access without diluting the method.

Where the lens comes from. Twenty years in the classroom, then corporate consulting and my years at USAID, often in rooms where many people were working in English as a second language. These are the moves that kept those rooms open to everyone.



Pre-mortem

A planning check in which a team imagines that its project has already failed and works backward to explain why, surfacing the risks that optimism and politeness usually keep quiet.

Origin: Developed by psychologist Gary Klein and described in Harvard Business Review (2007).

TIME 45–60 min **GROUP** 6–20 **RISK** MEDIUM

Send ahead: You will imagine the project has failed, list reasons alone, read one aloud in turn, then help cluster them at a wall.



It failed → reasons written in silence → top risks

Figure • Pre-mortem at a glance

PURPOSE

Most risk reviews ask "What might go wrong?", a question people answer cautiously, especially about a plan their manager likes. The Pre-mortem changes the frame: the failure has already happened, and everyone's job is to explain it. Imagining an outcome as having already happened helps people generate more specific reasons, and it gives everyone

permission to voice doubts without seeming disloyal. The output is a short list of top risks, each with an owner and a mitigation, produced while there is still time to change the plan.

HOW IT WORKS



- **Brief the Plan.** Walk through the plan in five minutes: the goal, the timeline, the key moves, and what success looks like, so everyone is reacting to the same version.
- **Announce the Failure.** Tell the group it is a year from now, the team went ahead with this plan, and the project failed. Make the failure clear, not a near miss, and pause to let the scenario land.
- **Write Reasons Silently.** Give everyone 3 to 5 minutes to write every reason they can think of for the failure, one per note, with no discussion.
- **Share Round-Robin.** Go around the group, each person reading out one reason at a time, until every reason is posted. Senior people go last, and only clarifying questions are allowed.
- **Cluster and Pick the Top Risks.** Group similar reasons, then use dot voting to choose the three to five risks that are most likely or would do the most damage.
- **Assign Owners and Mitigations.** For each top risk, agree a mitigation and an early-warning sign, name an owner, and set a date to check on it.

BENEFITS

- **Permission to Doubt.** Treating failure as a given makes it safe to raise concerns about a plan people are invested in.
- **Specific Risks.** Explaining a failure that has "already happened" produces concrete, named causes rather than general worries.
- **Every Voice Counts.** Silent writing and round-robin sharing collect risks from junior and quieter people before senior voices set the tone.
- **Owned Mitigations.** Each top risk leaves the room with a person and a date, not just a line in a risk register.

IN THE ROOM, YOU'LL KNOW IT'S WORKING WHEN

people name uncomfortable risks, including ones about leadership, timing, or politics, and the plan changes because of them

FIT

WORKS WELL WHEN

- A plan is nearly final but not yet launched, and there is still time to change it.
- The team is confident, invested, or under pressure to agree.
- The stakes are high and failure would be costly, public, or hard to reverse.

WATCH OUT FOR

- Running it too late: once the money is spent or the launch is announced, risks get noted and then ignored.
- Doom spiral: the session turns into an attack on the whole plan; the aim is to strengthen it, not cancel it.
- Leader first: if the sponsor reads their reasons first, others will echo them; senior people share last.

NEURODIVERSITY LENS

The Pre-mortem asks people to picture a vivid failure and then say critical things about a plan, sometimes one their manager owns. Some people find the imagined scenario

energizing; for others, an open-ended disaster story feels heavy or ambiguous unless it is framed clearly. The quiet thinking step already helps people who prefer to think before they speak, and a few small choices make the rest of the session work for more minds.

- **Send it ahead:** Say in the invitation that the session will imagine the project failing and that this is a thinking tool, not a prediction. Describe the steps: a few minutes alone listing reasons, then a round in which each person reads one aloud to the group, then clustering at a wall. Say plainly that the failure is imagined and deliberate, and that the plan has not actually failed.
- **Protect the quiet thinking time, and offer more than one way to capture it:** Give the full five minutes, and let people handwrite, type, sketch, tell a partner who writes it down, or submit reasons anonymously through a form or voice note, so no one has to attach their name to a sensitive risk.
- **Let people pass in the round-robin:** Allow a pass without explanation, and have the facilitator read anonymous notes aloud, so no one has to voice a risk about a powerful person in their own words.
- **Get people on their feet for clustering:** Have people bring their notes to the wall and group them by moving them, rather than clustering from their seats, and make it normal to step out during the failure story if it feels heavy.
- **Close on action, not dread:** End every session with owners and mitigations, and say clearly that the failure was imagined. People leave with a sense of control rather than a lingering worry.

FOR THE FACILITATOR

RUN THE SESSION

- Schedule it once the plan is drafted but before commitments are locked in.
- Invite people from across the work, including those who will deliver it and at least one known skeptic.
- Brief the plan, then deliver the failure scenario in a deliberate, matter-of-fact way.
- Time the silent writing and hold the room to no talking.
- Run the round-robin, senior people last, until every reason is on the wall.
- Cluster, vote, and assign owners before anyone leaves.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

- If a journalist wrote about why this failed, what would the headline say?
- What did we assume would go right that we never checked?
- What would you have said in the planning meeting if you had felt free to?
- Which of these risks would we see coming first, and what would the early sign be?

SAY THIS

FRAME Imagine it's a year from now. We went ahead with this plan, and it failed. Take five minutes, in silence, and write down every reason you can think of for why it failed.

NUDGE Go further than 'not enough resources.' What specifically ran out, when, and why didn't we see it coming?

LAND We have our top risks, each with an owner and a check date. The project hasn't failed. We've just made it harder to fail.

TIPS & WATCH-OUTS

- Make the failure unambiguous; "it went a bit badly" produces weak reasons.
- Ask the sponsor to stay, listen, and thank people for the hardest risks, not argue with them.
- Keep the full list of reasons, not just the top risks; the long list is useful when the plan is revised.
- Book a 15-minute check-in a month later to review progress on each mitigation.

FOR PARTICIPANTS

DURING

- Write as many specific reasons as you can, one per note.
- Include risks in your own area, not only in other people's.
- Share one reason at a time and hold debate until the clustering.

AFTER

- Watch for the early-warning signs the group named.
- Tell the risk owner as soon as you see a risk starting to show.

PAIRS WELL WITH

Assumption Map

Hypothetical Scenario Analysis

Who What When

After Action Review

- **Assumption Map.** Map the plan's assumptions first, then use the Pre-mortem to find which ones would sink the project if they proved wrong.
- **Hypothetical Scenario Analysis.** Explore a range of possible futures, then run a Pre-mortem on the plan against the most worrying one.
- **Who What When.** Turn each mitigation into an owned action with a date before the session closes.
- **After Action Review.** When the project ends, compare the risks you predicted with what actually happened, and sharpen the next Pre-mortem.

SUPPORTING TECH

- **Sticky notes and a wall.** One reason per note makes clustering fast in the room.
- **Miro, Mural, or FigJam.** A shared board for posting, clustering, and dot voting on reasons.
- **Slido, Mentimeter, Microsoft Forms, or Google Forms.** Collect reasons anonymously when the plan belongs to someone powerful in the room.

RUN IT ONLINE

- **Private Writing, Then Reveal.** Use Mural's private mode, or a separate form, so people write without seeing each other's reasons, then reveal everything onto one Miro or Mural board for clustering.
- **Anonymous Option.** Collect reasons through an open-ended Slido or Mentimeter poll and have the facilitator read them aloud, so sensitive risks arrive unattributed.
- **Post the Speaking Order.** Put the round-robin order in chat so no one waits unsure when to speak, keep cameras optional, and plan for the full 60 minutes online, with a timer on screen for the silent writing.
- **Hybrid.** Have in-room participants write on the same digital board instead of paper, so every reason sits in one place, and alternate the round-robin between the room and remote participants.

IN PRACTICE • HUMANITARIAN

Pre-mortem on a Mobile Cash Rollout

To stress-test a plan to switch 6,000 households from in-kind food to mobile cash before launch.

Six weeks before moving a host community from food distributions to mobile cash transfers, a program manager convened a pre-mortem with 12 staff, including two community mobilizers and the finance officer. She told them it was a year later and the cash program had been shut down. In five minutes of silent writing, the team produced more than 40 reasons. The round-robin surfaced risks the plan had missed: network outages on distribution days, women without SIM cards registered in their own names, and local traders raising prices once cash arrived. The team chose four top risks. The mobilizers took on a SIM registration drive with the network provider, finance arranged a cash-in-envelope fallback for outage days, and the program added a weekly market price check. Launch slipped by two weeks, and the registration gap closed before the first transfer.

IN PRACTICE • CORPORATE

Market Entry Offsite

To test a confident market-entry plan before the board approved its budget.

At its annual offsite, a consumer-goods company's eight-person leadership team was two weeks from asking the board to fund entry into a neighboring country. The plan had been through four reviews, and everyone called it solid. The facilitator ran a 60-minute pre-mortem after lunch, with the CEO agreeing to share last. Silent writing produced 31 reasons. The surprise was how many pointed to the same place: three executives had independently written that the distribution partner was chosen in a hurry and no one had checked its capacity. Nobody had said so in the reviews, because the CEO had championed that partner. The team kept the plan but made a capacity audit of the distributor a condition of launch and named a fallback partner. The CEO thanked the group for the risk he had least wanted to hear.

SIGNAL OF IMPACT • 60-90 DAYS

Sixty to ninety days in, the team has acted on at least one early-warning sign it named, and new plans arrive with a pre-mortem already on the calendar.



After Action Review

A structured, blameless debrief, held soon after an event, in which the people who did the work compare what was supposed to happen with what actually happened and decide what to sustain or improve next time.

Origin: Developed by the US Army in the 1970s and now standard practice in humanitarian response.

TIME 30–60 min **GROUP** 4–20 **RISK** MEDIUM

Send ahead: You will help rebuild the event's timeline at a shared wall, then talk through the gaps as a group. Bring notes in any form.

PLANNED	ACTUAL	WHY	NEXT TIME
The intent	What happened	Cause of the gap	Sustain or improve

Figure • After Action Review at a glance

PURPOSE

The After Action Review turns experience into learning while memories are still fresh. Four plain questions move the group from intent, to facts, to causes, to commitments, so the conversation stays on how the work went rather than on who got it wrong. Held routinely after every significant event, AARs build a habit of learning in the flow of work instead of saving lessons for a final report that nobody reads.

HOW IT WORKS



How After Action Review flows, step by step

- **Set the Ground Rules.** Name the event and the time window under review, and state plainly that the review is blameless: the group is here to learn about the work, not to judge people. Rank stays at the door, and only the agreed actions leave the room.
- **What Was Supposed to Happen?** Reconstruct the intent as it stood at the time: the plan, the objectives, the standards, and the assumptions. Disagreement here is useful, because it often shows that people were working to different plans.
- **What Actually Happened?** Build one factual timeline from everyone's vantage point before anyone interprets it. Ask the people closest to the work to speak first.
- **Why Was There a Difference?** Examine each gap between plan and reality, including things that went better than planned, and look for causes in systems, information, and decisions rather than in individuals.
- **What Will We Sustain or Improve?** Name the specific practices to keep and the specific changes to make next time, each worded as something a person can actually do.
- **Assign Owners and Close the Loop.** Give every improvement an owner and a date, record the lessons in a one-page note, and send it to the people who will run the next similar event.

BENEFITS

- **Learning While It Is Fresh.** Captures what happened within days, before memories blur and the story gets tidier than the reality.
- **Blameless by Design.** The four questions point at the work, not the people, which makes it safer to admit mistakes and report near misses.
- **One Shared Picture.** People who saw different parts of the event build a single account of it together.
- **Lessons That Travel.** Short, specific notes can be handed to the next team that faces the same situation.

IN THE ROOM, YOU'LL KNOW IT'S WORKING WHEN

people describe their own mistakes plainly, without defending them, and the improvement list names changes the group can actually make

FIT

WORKS WELL WHEN

- A discrete event has just ended: a response, a launch, a training, an incident, or an event day.
- The same kind of work will happen again, so the lessons have somewhere to go.
- You want a routine learning habit rather than a one-off investigation.

WATCH OUT FOR

- Blame creep: the conversation drifts to who failed; steer it back to what happened and why.
- Waiting too long: after a few weeks, people reconstruct a neater story than the one they lived.
- Rank in the room: if the person who led the event facilitates or speaks first, others will edit what they say.

NEURODIVERSITY LENS

An AAR asks people to recall events accurately, talk about what went wrong in front of colleagues, and hold analysis and emotion at the same time, often while they are still tired from the work itself. Memory under pressure is uneven, and some people need time to sort sequence and detail before they can speak to it. Advance notice, more than one way to contribute, and a calm room make the review both fairer and more accurate.

- **Send it ahead:** Put the four questions, the event, and the time window in the invitation, and say how the hour will run: people will rebuild the timeline together at a wall or shared board, then talk through the gaps as a group. Invite them to bring notes in any form, so nobody has to reconstruct events on the spot.
- **Build the timeline more than one way:** Have everyone add events to a shared timeline on notes, by telling a partner or the facilitator who posts them, or by marking a rough sketch, with a minute of quiet thinking before each question. Put the timeline on a wall so people can stand, walk the sequence, and move notes as the picture firms up. This reduces reliance on whoever tells the story most fluently.
- **Offer an anonymous route:** Let people submit their "what happened" and "why" points without a name, as a note, a form, or a voice note the facilitator transcribes, especially when the event involved errors, so social risk does not filter the facts.
- **Keep the room calm and the session short:** Hold it somewhere quiet, cap it at an hour, and make it normal to step out. After a hard event, separate the emotional debrief from the operational review so neither crowds out the other.

FOR THE FACILITATOR

RUN THE SESSION

- Schedule the AAR within a few days of the event and invite everyone who did the work, not only the leads.
- Where possible, ask someone who did not lead the event to facilitate, so the leader can take part as a peer.
- Open with the ground rules and post the four questions where everyone can see them.
- Work through the questions in order; do not let "why" start until the group agrees on what happened.

- Push lessons from general to specific: "communicate better" becomes "send the shift handover in one message by 6 p.m."
- Close with owners and dates, and send the one-page summary within 48 hours.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

- What were we trying to achieve, and what did success look like at the start?
- Where does your view of what happened differ from someone else's?
- What surprised us, for better or worse?
- What would we do the same way if this happened again tomorrow?
- Who else needs to hear this lesson?

SAY THIS

FRAME This is a blameless review. We're here to understand how the work went, not to judge anyone. We'll take four questions in order: what was supposed to happen, what actually happened, why there was a difference, and what we'll sustain or improve.

NUDGE Let's stay with what happened before we explain it. What did you see from where you were standing?

LAND Here are our sustains and our improves, each with a name and a date. I'll send the one-page summary by Thursday, and we'll open the next review by checking these.

TIPS & WATCH-OUTS

- Hold it soon: a 30-minute AAR this week beats a thorough one next month.
- Give "sustain" as much time as "improve"; what went well is a lesson too, and it is the one most easily lost.
- If the event leader has to facilitate, have them speak last on every question and ask someone else to take notes.
- Keep the written record in the same format every time, so lessons build up and can be searched before the next event.
- For schools, the companion book *Couldn't Have Been an Email* has a one-page AAR meeting rhythm you can adopt as it stands.

FOR PARTICIPANTS

DURING

- Bring notes on what you saw and did.
- Describe what happened before explaining why.
- Speak plainly about your own part, including mistakes.
- Listen for where your account differs from others', and say so.

AFTER

- Follow through on any action you own, by the date agreed.
- Use the lessons when you plan the next similar event.

PAIRS WELL WITH

Five Whys

Who What When

Pre-mortem

Plus-Delta

- **Five Whys.** When question three exposes a stubborn gap, drill into it with Five Whys before agreeing what to improve.
- **Who What When.** Turn the sustain and improve list into owned actions with dates before the group leaves.
- **Pre-mortem.** Feed the AAR's lessons into a Pre-mortem on the next plan, so last time's failures become this time's named risks.
- **Plus-Delta.** Use Plus-Delta as the lighter version for small, routine events, and save the full AAR for the ones that matter.

SUPPORTING TECH

- **Flip chart or whiteboard.** Four columns or a timeline across the top is all the in-room AAR needs.
- **Miro, Mural, or FigJam.** A shared timeline board that people can add to before and during the session.
- **Microsoft Forms or Google Forms.** Collect anonymous answers to the four questions ahead of the session.
- **A shared lessons log.** One document or spreadsheet with the same headings for every AAR, so lessons can be searched later.

RUN IT ONLINE

- **Timeline First.** Set up a Miro or FigJam board with a timeline across the top and a frame for each question, and give everyone ten silent minutes to add notes to the timeline before anyone speaks.
- **Anonymous Input.** Send a Microsoft Forms or Google Forms survey with the four questions a day ahead, open the session by showing the themes, and use chat for quick additions during discussion.
- **Breakouts for Larger Teams.** With more than eight people, split into breakout rooms by function for question three, then bring each room's top two causes back to the main room. Keep online AARs to 60 minutes and split a large event across two sessions.
- **Hybrid.** Put the timeline on the shared board, not the room's wall, so remote staff (often the ones who were in the field) add to and see the same notes, and call on remote people first for each question.

IN PRACTICE • HUMANITARIAN

Flood Response Field Review

To capture lessons from a two-week flood response before half the team rotated out.

Two weeks into a flood response in a river delta district, a 14-person field team had distributed hygiene kits and water purification tablets to about 3,000 households, and half the team was due to rotate out within days. With the office still without power, the coordinator asked a protection officer from another program, who had not led the response, to facilitate a 60-minute AAR under a tarp at the warehouse. The plan had assumed road access by day three. The timeline showed that trucks did not reach the two furthest villages until day eight, and that community boat operators had been ready from day two, but nobody had asked them. The "why" traced back to a partner contact list that lived on one person's phone. The team agreed to sustain joint registration with village leaders and to pre-agree boat transport with community partners before the next rainy season, with a named owner for each.

IN PRACTICE • CORPORATE

Checkout Outage Review

To learn from a four-hour checkout outage without turning the review into a hunt for whoever pushed the change.

A home-goods retailer's e-commerce operations team lost checkout for four hours on the busiest Saturday of the year, and the head of engineering wanted names. Instead, a delivery lead from another product team facilitated a 60-minute AAR three days later with the 11 people involved, including the on-call engineer and the customer service lead. Building the timeline in silence on a shared board took 15 minutes and settled two arguments about sequence. The surprise was the cause: a change freeze existed in the plan but had never reached a contractor team. The group agreed to sustain the incident chat channel, which had worked well, and to route future freeze notices through vendor managers. The on-call engineer, who had expected to be blamed, volunteered to own the follow-up.

SIGNAL OF IMPACT • 60-90 DAYS

Sixty to ninety days on, improvements from the last AAR show up in the plan for the next event, and teams ask for an AAR without being prompted.



Brainwriting

Brainwriting is a silent brainstorming technique where participants write ideas individually and then build on each other's ideas by passing sheets in a structured rotation.

Origin: Developed by Bernd Rohrbach, who published the 6-3-5 format in the German sales magazine Absatzwirtschaft in 1968.

TIME 20–45 min **GROUP** 4–30 **RISK** LOW

Send ahead: You will work silently on your own, seated, writing or sketching ideas on a sheet, then building on sheets passed from your neighbors.

PURPOSE

Brainwriting produces a large number of ideas quickly and fairly. Because everyone writes at the same time instead of taking turns to speak, no one waits for airtime, no one is judged mid-sentence, and the quietest person's ideas reach the page as easily as the most confident person's.

HOW IT WORKS

1 Write Silently



2 Pass the Paper



3 Keep Building

How Brainwriting flows, step by step

- **Write Silently.** Participants write ideas on paper in response to a prompt. A common format, 6-3-5, has six people each write three ideas in five minutes.
- **Pass the Paper.** Each participant passes their sheet to the next person, who reads it and adds ideas that build on what is there.

- **Keep Building.** The rotation continues until each sheet has passed through most of the group or the ideas run out.

BENEFITS

- **Inclusivity.** Ensures quieter participants' ideas are considered.
- **Diverse Perspectives.** Encourages a variety of perspectives and solutions.
- **Focus.** Lets participants concentrate without group distractions.
- **Efficiency.** Everyone generates at once, so a group of six can produce a hundred ideas in half an hour.

IN THE ROOM, YOU'LL KNOW IT'S WORKING WHEN

quieter participants' ideas are on the sheets and getting built on, without anyone dominating the room

NEURODIVERSITY LENS

Brainwriting separates generating ideas from saying them out loud. The silent format removes the social pressure of being heard and evaluated in real time, a real advantage for participants who think more fluently when they are not competing with faster or louder voices. It does move the load onto writing and onto reading other people's handwriting, which is the barrier, not the relief, for dyslexic participants and people with dysgraphia, so the input routes matter as much as the silence.

- **Send it ahead:** Share the prompt and the format before the session: people will work silently and on their own, seated, adding ideas to a sheet or screen, then reading and building on sheets passed from their neighbors in timed rounds. Say up front that typed, sketched, and dictated ideas all count.
- **Name silence as the method:** Some participants will find a quiet room unfamiliar in a group setting. Framing the silence as an intentional design feature, not an awkward pause, normalizes the experience from the start.
- **Offer more than one way to get ideas down:** Let people type, handwrite, sketch, jot a few keywords, or quietly tell a partner who writes it down; in a remote version, a voice note into the shared doc works too. Use typed sheets or a shared digital board where you can, so nobody has to decode handwriting, and offer to read an incoming sheet aloud quietly to anyone who wants it.

- **Set a minimum, not a maximum:** "Add at least one idea per round" removes the fear of falling short while preserving space for participants who generate prolifically.
- **Keep the rhythm predictable and the body free:** Announce the rotation cadence at the outset, keep a visible timer, and stick to it. Let people stand, stretch, or walk sheets to the next person between rounds, and keep fidget items on the table.

FOR THE FACILITATOR

RUN THE SESSION

- Before the session, write the prompt as a question ("How might we...?") and put it at the top of every sheet. For 6-3-5, draw a grid of three columns and six rows on each sheet.
- Seat people at tables of four to six. Spend two minutes on the rules: three ideas per round, no talking, and any idea can build on, combine, or ignore what is already on the sheet.
- Run the first round for five minutes on a visible timer. Walk the room quietly; if someone is stuck, suggest a single word or a quick sketch.
- Call each pass aloud. From the second round on, allow an extra minute for reading. Stop when the sheets have gone around the table or the rows are full: about 20 minutes for a table of four, 30 for six.
- Give five minutes for each person to read the sheet in front of them and star the two ideas they would develop.
- Harvest the starred ideas onto the wall, one per note, and hand them to Affinity Mapping or Nominal Group Technique. Keep every sheet; the unstarred ideas are useful later.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

- What is the specific topic or challenge for brainstorming?
- How can your idea help solve the problem or address the topic?
- Can you build on the ideas already on the paper you received?
- What unique insight can you add to the existing ideas?

SAY THIS

FRAME This round is silent on purpose: here's the prompt, and for the next few minutes just write your ideas on your sheet, no talking, no judging.

NUDGE Pens slowing down? Say, 'Pass your sheet now, read what's there, and add one idea that builds on it,' to restart the flow.

LAND Now let's surface what grew on these sheets: notice how many ideas came from people who might not have spoken up out loud.

TIPS & WATCH-OUTS

- Enforce the silence early; the quiet is what makes this fairer than open brainstorming.
- Time each round and signal the pass clearly so sheets keep circulating.
- If someone freezes on a blank sheet, tell them to build on the idea above rather than invent from scratch.
- Brainwriting and Idea Storm both start with silent individual writing, but Brainwriting stays silent and grows ideas on the passed sheets, while Idea Storm moves into small-group discussion; choose Brainwriting when talking would let a few voices take over.

FOR PARTICIPANTS

DURING

- Read and understand the prompt.
- Silently write your ideas for the set time.
- Pass your paper when instructed.
- Read the paper you receive and add or elaborate.
- Respect others' ideas and build on them constructively.

PAIRS WELL WITH

Problem Statement

Affinity Mapping

Nominal Group Technique (NGT)

SWOT Analysis

- **Problem Statement.** Agree on the problem first and use it, word for word, as the brainwriting prompt.
- **Affinity Mapping.** Cut the sheets into single ideas and cluster them in silence to find the themes.
- **Nominal Group Technique (NGT).** Carry the brainwriting ideas into NGT's clarification and private ranking to reach a decision.

- **SWOT Analysis.** Use four rounds of brainwriting, one per quadrant, to fill a SWOT without the loudest voice setting the list.

SUPPORTING TECH

- **Collaborative Document Tools.** Platforms like Google Docs or Microsoft Word for the web let participants contribute to a shared document simultaneously, a digital version of brainwriting.
- **Online Whiteboards.** Tools like Miro, Mural, or Stormboard provide a virtual space where participants can write and organize their ideas, simulating the paper-passing process digitally.

RUN IT ONLINE

- **One Column per Person.** Set up a board or shared spreadsheet with one column per participant and three empty rows per round; at each pass, everyone moves one column to the right and adds to it.
- **Anonymous by Default.** Turn off name labels on sticky notes or use an unattributed shared doc, so ideas are read on their merits during the rotation.
- **Call the Pass Clearly.** Announce each pass aloud and in the chat with the column number people should move to, and add five minutes to the total for people finding their place.
- **Hybrid.** Run the whole rotation digitally for everyone, including people in the room on laptops; mixing paper sheets and digital columns makes it impossible for ideas to pass between the two groups.

IN PRACTICE • HUMANITARIAN

Enhancing Disaster Preparedness for Vulnerable Communities

Participants silently wrote ideas for improving disaster preparedness, then passed their sheets so others could build on them. Ideas ranged from community-based early warning systems to mobile healthcare units. The session yielded a wealth of diverse ideas. An early warning concept, for example, expanded to involve local schools in awareness programs, creating a comprehensive, community-driven plan. This inclusive approach rooted the strategies in the needs and resources of vulnerable communities, strengthening their resilience.

IN PRACTICE • CORPORATE

Delayed Departure Communication

To collect ideas from a mixed-seniority group where junior staff rarely spoke first.

A regional airline's customer-experience lead wanted ideas for handling delayed departures better, and gathered 12 cabin crew, gate agents, and two station managers. In earlier meetings, the station managers had done most of the talking. The facilitator ran a 6-3-5 Brainwriting with two tables of six: three ideas each, five minutes, then pass. After five passes, the sheets held over 150 ideas. The most built-on idea came from a first-year gate agent: announce a realistic estimate with a reason, even when it is bad news, instead of rolling 15-minute updates. Eight people had extended it on later sheets. The managers took that idea, with the crew's refinements, into a three-month trial at two stations.



Sailboat

The Sailboat metaphor explores goals, obstacles, and strategies in a visually engaging way.

Origin: Adapted from Luke Hohmann's Speed Boat game in Innovation Games (2006).

TIME 45–60 min **GROUP** 4–15 **RISK** MEDIUM

Send ahead: You will stand and post notes on a shared drawing in view of colleagues, then discuss as a group. Anchors can be posted anonymously.

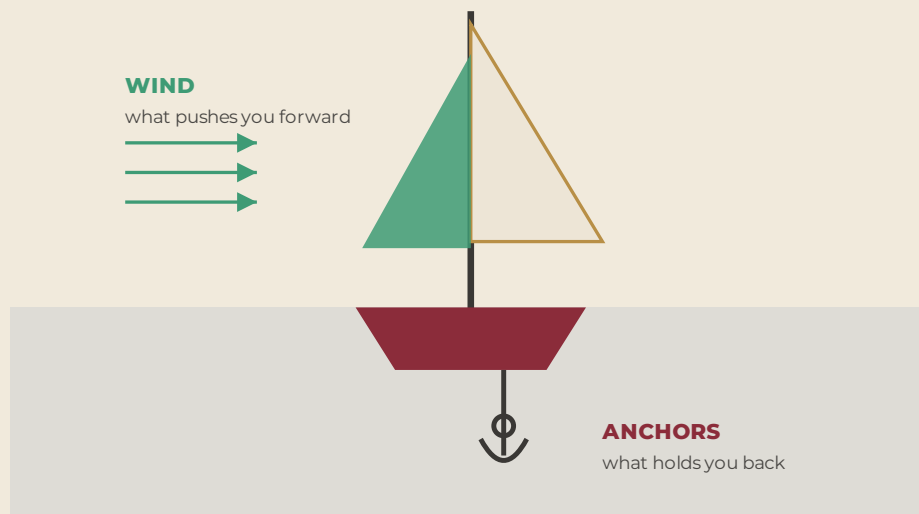


Figure • Sailboat at a glance

PURPOSE

Sailboat helps participants navigate challenges and stay on course toward their desired outcomes. Putting the goal, the forces helping, and the forces holding the team back on one picture lets a group see the whole situation at once and turn complaints into specific next moves.

HOW IT WORKS



- **Draw the Sailboat.** Sketch a sailboat on a whiteboard to represent the project.
- **Add the Island.** Draw a distant island for the desired goal or outcome.
- **Name the Winds.** Identify positive factors propelling the boat toward the goal.
- **Spot the Anchors.** Identify obstacles and barriers that hinder progress.
- **Set the Sails.** Discuss strategies that harness the winds and lift the anchors.
- **Adjust the Course.** Move notes, mark the heaviest anchors and strongest winds, and redraw the course to show the plan the group has agreed.

BENEFITS

- **Visualization.** Represents goals and obstacles visually, making them easier to grasp.
- **Engagement.** Gives people a picture to react to, which makes it easier to name uncomfortable obstacles than in a plain list.
- **Collaboration.** Prompts participants to work together to navigate the boat.

IN THE ROOM, YOU'LL KNOW IT'S WORKING WHEN

the group stops listing problems and starts naming specific strategies to raise the anchors and catch the wind

NEURODIVERSITY LENS

A visual metaphor like the Sailboat gives people something concrete to react to when abstract strategic language is hard to get hold of. The wind, anchor, and sail vocabulary gives everyone a shared reference point regardless of experience level, role, or professional background.

- **Send it ahead:** Share the picture, the zone labels, and the question each zone asks before the session, and explain the shape: people will add notes to a shared drawing on a wall, standing and posting in view of colleagues, and then discuss as a group. Mention that anchors can be raised anonymously.
- **Pre-draw the sailboat and keep the labels up:** Arrive with the image already on the board and label every zone, leaving the labels up throughout, so no one has to remember which zone is wind and which is anchor while also generating ideas.
- **One idea per note, more than one way to make one:** One idea per note allows re-sorting and makes contributions feel less permanent, which encourages candor. Let people write, sketch, or say the idea to a partner who writes it down.
- **Allow anonymous contributions for the anchors:** Naming obstacles carries social risk. Accept anchors on unsigned notes passed forward, typed into a shared doc, or told to the facilitator privately, which often produces more honest and useful material.
- **Avoid a crowd at the wall:** Post in small waves rather than all at once, let people hand notes to a runner instead of walking up, and give the wall enough space that nobody is pressed shoulder to shoulder.

FOR THE FACILITATOR

RUN THE SESSION

- Draw a simple sailboat and island on a whiteboard or flipchart.
- Ask participants to identify winds and anchors for the project.
- Facilitate a discussion on strategies for overcoming obstacles.
- Encourage participants to adjust the sailboat as needed.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

- What is our desired goal (island)?
- What factors are propelling us forward (winds)?

- What obstacles might hinder our progress (anchors)?
- How can strategies (sails) overcome the barriers and reach our goal?

SAY THIS

FRAME We're going to draw our project as a sailboat heading for an island, so let's start by naming the island: what does reaching our goal actually look like?

NUDGE Stuck? Point at the anchors and ask, 'Which one is heaviest right now?' then pick just that one to work on.

LAND Look at the sails we listed: those are our next moves, so let's pick the two we can raise this week.

TIPS & WATCH-OUTS

- Draw the boat, island, wind, and anchor before anyone speaks so people react to a picture, not a blank page.
- Sort winds and anchors onto sticky notes first, then cluster before discussing strategies.
- If it stalls on complaints, redirect every anchor into a sail: 'What action helps us lift that one?'

FOR PARTICIPANTS

DURING

- Visualize the desired goal (island) for the project.
- Identify positive factors (winds) that support progress.
- Recognize obstacles (anchors) that need addressing.
- Propose strategies (sails) to overcome barriers.
- Collaborate with others to navigate the sailboat.

PAIRS WELL WITH

Newspaper Headline

Impact Effort Map

OKRs (Objectives and Key Results)

- **Newspaper Headline.** Write the headline first, then use it as the island so everyone is sailing toward the same named destination.

- **Impact Effort Map.** Plot the proposed sails by impact and effort to choose which two or three to act on first.
- **OKRs (Objectives and Key Results).** Turn the island into an objective and the most important sails into key results with owners and dates.

SUPPORTING TECH

- **Digital Whiteboards.** Miro, Mural, or Lucidspark for drawing the boat and collecting notes during virtual facilitation.
- **FigJam.** Ready-made sailboat retrospective templates and sticky notes for collaborative visual work.

RUN IT ONLINE

- **Pre-Built Board.** Set up the boat, island, wind, and anchor zones on a Miro or FigJam board before the call, with a labeled stack of blank notes in each zone, so the first minute is spent thinking, not drawing.
- **Anonymous Anchors.** Turn on anonymous sticky notes, or collect anchors through a Slido or Microsoft Forms question, for the obstacles section, where naming a colleague's process or a leader's decision carries real risk.
- **Short Rounds.** Run each zone as its own five-minute silent round with a timer, then send small groups to breakout rooms to draft sails for one heavy anchor each. Online, allow the full 60 minutes.
- **Hybrid.** Put the digital board on the room screen and give in-room participants laptops or phones to add notes directly, rather than having one person transcribe a physical wall for the remote group.

IN PRACTICE • HUMANITARIAN

Emergency Response Coordination

After a summer of wildfires, a county health office's emergency response team met to look at why coordination with neighboring counties had been slow. Participants used the Sailboat metaphor to identify winds (strong communication, a skilled team) that supported their emergency response goals and anchors (limited resources, logistical challenges) that hindered progress. They discussed strategies (raising funds, optimizing resource allocation) to overcome obstacles and reach their coordination goals. The team left with

two agreed actions, each with an owner: a shared contact list with the neighboring counties and a joint funding request for spare equipment.

IN PRACTICE • CORPORATE

Depot Managers After a Missed Peak Season

To understand why on-time delivery slipped across depots without turning the review into blame.

A logistics firm's 11 depot managers met two weeks after a holiday peak in which on-time delivery had fallen short at most sites. Earlier reviews had become arguments between depots and head office. The facilitator pre-drew the sailboat, named the island "next peak on time," and collected anchors on unsigned notes before any discussion. Fourteen anchors came in; nine were about late changes to driver rosters, which head office had assumed was a problem at only two depots. The winds were just as revealing: two depots had kept a small reserve of agency drivers, and nobody else knew. The group drafted sails for the three heaviest anchors and agreed on a roster freeze date for the next peak, which the regional director signed off before the meeting closed.



Nominal Group Technique (NGT)

A structured method for generating and ranking ideas in which everyone writes silently, shares in turn, and ranks privately, so every participant has an equal voice.

Origin: Developed by André Delbecq and Andrew Van de Ven around 1970.

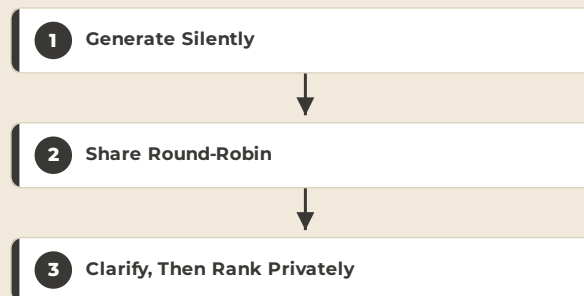
TIME 1.5–2 hr **GROUP** 5–12 **RISK** MEDIUM

Send ahead: You'll write ideas alone in silence, share one aloud in turn, discuss briefly, then rank privately; nobody sees your ranking.

PURPOSE

Ensures all ideas are heard and considered, reducing dominance by louder voices.

HOW IT WORKS



How Nominal Group Technique (NGT) flows, step by step

- **Generate Silently.** Participants individually write ideas in silence.
- **Share Round-Robin.** Each participant shares one idea at a time in turn.
- **Clarify, Then Rank Privately.** The group briefly clarifies each idea, then members rank the list privately and the facilitator pools the scores.

BENEFITS

- **Equal Participation.** Gives everyone an equal chance to contribute without interruption.
- **Structured Process.** Provides a systematic approach to generating and ranking ideas.

- **Consensus Building.** Guides the group toward agreement on the most important ideas.
- **Reduced Dominance.** Limits dominant voices and draws out quieter participants.

IN THE ROOM, YOU'LL KNOW IT'S WORKING WHEN

the quietest people in the room have ideas on the list, and the final ranking reflects the whole group, not one or two voices

NEURODIVERSITY LENS

NGT's silent generation, structured round-robin, and private ranking each remove a different barrier to equal participation. Facilitators who understand why these structural choices matter will implement them with more fidelity and resist the temptation to shortcut the phases when time feels tight.

- **Send it ahead:** Send the question and the four phases before the session: quiet idea generation on your own, a round in which each person shares one idea aloud in turn, a short clarifying discussion, and private ranking. People can arrive with ideas already formed.
- **Hold the quiet generation phase non-negotiably:** The value of NGT depends on individual thinking happening before social influence. Even a few minutes of premature discussion significantly skews the range of ideas that enter the room.
- **Offer more than one way to capture ideas:** During the quiet phase, let people list ideas in writing, as quick sketches, as a voice note with earbuds, or by telling a scribe in a side space, so the "silent writing" step does not shut out people for whom writing is the barrier.
- **Use a standard turn cue and record verbatim:** A passed object or a numbered order on the board makes turn-taking predictable, and a pass is always allowed. Record each idea in the speaker's words without summarizing or grouping, since editing in real time signals that some contributions count less.
- **Separate prioritization from discussion explicitly:** Make clear that the group clarifies ideas together but ranks privately, and let them rank by placing numbered cards or dots rather than only by writing. Blending these phases lets dominant voices anchor others' rankings.

- **Break up the long sit:** NGT often runs 90 minutes seated. Have people stand to place ranking dots at the wall, take a stretch break between sharing and ranking, and make it normal to step out.

FOR THE FACILITATOR

RUN THE SESSION

- Explain the NGT process and the value of equal participation.
- Have participants write ideas individually in silence.
- Run the round-robin, one idea per turn, without evaluation.
- Lead a short clarification round on any idea that is unclear, then have everyone rank privately and tally the results.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

- What is the specific topic for idea generation?
- How can we keep idea generation silent to avoid bias?
- What criteria should participants use to prioritize ideas?

SAY THIS

FRAME First, everyone writes their own ideas silently, no talking. Then we go around the room, one idea each, until we've heard them all.

NUDGE If someone passes when it's their turn, that's fine; we'll come back around, and a half-formed idea still counts.

LAND Every idea is up and nobody talked over anyone. Now let's rank them together and see what rises to the top.

TIPS & WATCH-OUTS

- Enforce true silence during idea generation so no one anchors on the loudest voice before writing.
- Take exactly one idea per person per round, with no comment or debate, until the list is exhausted.

- If a dominant voice starts steering, point back to the round-robin: one idea, then it's the next person's turn.

FOR PARTICIPANTS

DURING

- Silently generate ideas on the topic.
- Listen without interruption during round-robin sharing.
- Ask questions to clarify ideas, not to argue for them.
- Rank privately; your ranking counts as much as anyone's.
- Respect others' views and stay open to revising yours.

PAIRS WELL WITH

Affinity Mapping

Rank Order Voting

Delphi Method

- **Affinity Mapping.** If the round-robin produces a long list, cluster duplicates into themes before the private ranking.
- **Rank Order Voting.** Use a formal ranking ballot for the final step when the stakes are high and the result needs to be defensible.
- **Delphi Method.** When experts cannot meet in one room, run the same silent-input and private-ranking logic across written rounds.

SUPPORTING TECH

- **Online Survey Tools (e.g., SurveyMonkey, Google Forms, Microsoft Forms).** Useful for initial idea collection and private ranking, especially for remote or large groups.
- **Collaborative Decision-Making Software (e.g., GroupMap, IdeaScale).** Supports virtual NGT sessions, allowing participants to contribute and prioritize ideas online.

RUN IT ONLINE

- **Silent Writing Off Camera.** Ask people to write ideas in a private document or on paper for eight to ten minutes, with cameras optional, and resist the urge to fill the silence.
- **Round-Robin by Name.** Post the speaking order in chat and call each name in turn while a scribe types every idea verbatim into a numbered list on screen; let people type 'pass' in chat if they have nothing new.

- **Private Ranking.** Run the ranking as an anonymous ranking question in Mentimeter, Slido, or Microsoft Forms, so no one sees how others voted until the results appear. Online, allow about 15 extra minutes for transitions.
- **Hybrid.** Interleave in-room and remote people in the round-robin order rather than going room first, so remote participants are not left with only the ideas nobody else has said.

IN PRACTICE • HUMANITARIAN

Improving Community Participation in Disaster Preparedness Drills

In a flood-prone county, turnout at disaster preparedness drills had fallen two years running, and the local committee could not agree why. A facilitator ran the Nominal Group Technique with twelve members. Participants generated ideas silently, such as promoting events on social media, involving local schools, and organizing community contests. Ideas were shared round-robin, clarified, and ranked privately, and the group selected a neighborhood recognition program as its top pick. The committee ran it before the next drill, and two neighborhoods that had sent almost nobody the year before took part.

IN PRACTICE • CORPORATE

Reducing Overtime on Nursing Units

To get candid ideas from unit managers who rarely contradicted their chief nursing officer.

A community hospital's 18 nurse managers met at two tables of nine to tackle rising overtime, a topic on which the chief nursing officer usually set the direction and the room followed. The facilitator ran Nominal Group Technique in 90 minutes: ten minutes of silent writing, then a round-robin in which each manager offered one idea at a time while a scribe at each table recorded it word for word. The two lists reached 41 ideas between them. After a short clarification round, each manager privately ranked their top five on a card. The top-ranked idea, a float pool shared across three units, came from a night-shift manager who had never raised it in a meeting before. The chief nursing officer said afterward that she would not have heard it in an open discussion. The float-pool pilot started the next month.

Six Thinking Hats

A technique for group and individual thinking that examines a problem from six distinct perspectives.

Origin: Created by Edward de Bono (1985). Six Thinking Hats® is a registered trademark of Edward de Bono Limited.

TIME 1–2 hr **GROUP** 4–12 **RISK** MEDIUM

Send ahead: The group thinks in one mode at a time, speaking in turn or adding notes; nothing said under a hat counts as your own view.



WHITE
Facts & data



RED
Feelings



BLACK
Caution



YELLOW
Benefits



GREEN
New ideas



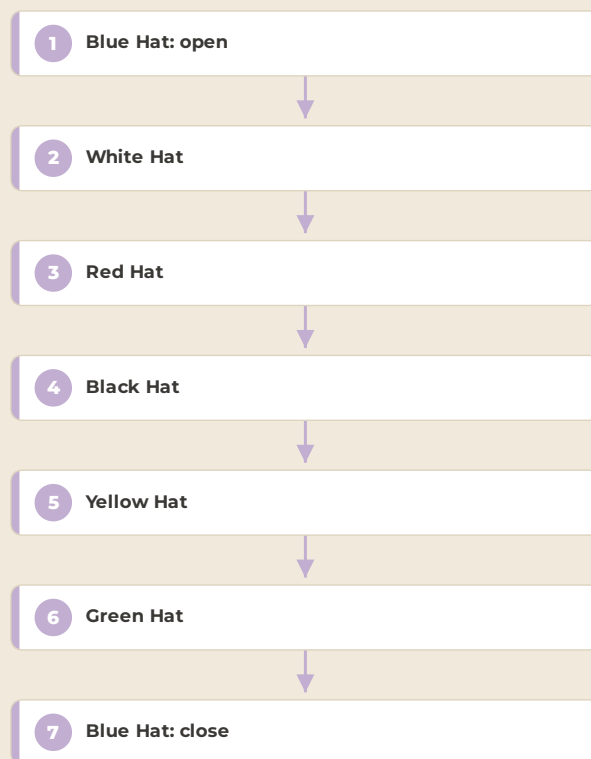
BLUE
Process

Figure • Six Thinking Hats at a glance

PURPOSE

Each hat represents one mode of thinking, and the whole group wears the same hat at the same time, so facts, feelings, risks, benefits, and new ideas each get dedicated attention instead of competing in one argument.

HOW IT WORKS



How Six Thinking Hats flows, step by step

- **Blue Hat (open).** Sets the focus: the question on the table, the order of the hats, and the time for each.
- **White Hat.** Focuses on facts, figures, and information known or needed.
- **Red Hat.** Represents emotions, intuition, and gut feelings.
- **Black Hat.** Identifies problems, risks, and obstacles.
- **Yellow Hat.** Looks at benefits, opportunities, and positive outcomes.
- **Green Hat.** Sparks creative thinking and new alternatives.
- **Blue Hat (close).** Pulls the threads together, summarizes what each hat surfaced, and decides next steps. Whoever is facilitating wears the Blue Hat throughout.

BENEFITS

- **Holistic Analysis.** Balances facts, emotions, risks, benefits, and creativity.
- **Structured Discussion.** Gives group discussion a clear framework, minimizing chaos.
- **Encourages Participation.** Lets everyone contribute from multiple angles.

- **Critical Thinking.** Separates judging an idea from generating it, so criticism has its place without crowding out new options.

IN THE ROOM, YOU'LL KNOW IT'S WORKING WHEN

risks, feelings, facts, and fresh ideas have each had dedicated airtime, and no single hat quietly ran the whole conversation

NEURODIVERSITY LENS

The hat metaphor is one of the most effective permission structures in facilitation – it gives participants explicit license to think in a particular mode without that mode being interpreted as their personal position. Because everyone wears the same hat at the same time, nobody has to defend a feeling or a doubt as their own position; the hat makes room for it.

- **Send it ahead:** Send the question and the hat key. Explain that the whole group thinks in one mode at a time, roughly how long each hat lasts, that people can speak in turn or add notes, and that no one has to defend what they say under a hat as their own view.
- **Make the hats physical:** Use colored hats or cards that people hold or place on the table, or post a colored wall section for each hat and have people move to it to add their contributions. A visible, physical cue makes mode-switching concrete and gets people out of their seats across a 1–2 hour session.
- **Display the hat key throughout the session:** A visible reference showing each hat's color, name, and one-sentence description saves people from holding the framework in memory while also generating contributions.
- **Offer more than one way to contribute:** Under each hat, let people speak, add a note, or tell a scribe. Ideas that belong to a different hat go to a parking board by any of those routes, so they are captured without disrupting the current focus.
- **Debrief the hat-switching experience, not just the content:** Ask participants what it felt like to think from each perspective. This builds insight into their own thinking preferences and makes the framework a lasting tool rather than a one-time exercise.

FOR THE FACILITATOR

RUN THE SESSION

- Open in Blue Hat (5 min): state the question, the order of the hats, and the time for each, and post the order where everyone can see it.
- Run each hat in turn (5–10 min each). Everyone wears the same hat at the same time; capture comments under that hat's heading.
- Hold the hat: if criticism comes up during Yellow, note it for Black and move on.
- Keep Red short (2–3 min): feelings and hunches, no reasons needed.
- Close in Blue Hat (10 min): summarize what each hat produced, then name the decision or next step and who owns it.

QUESTIONS TO ASK

- What are the key facts about the problem?
- How do you feel about it? What are your hunches?
- What issues or challenges could the solutions raise?
- What benefits and opportunities might addressing it bring?
- What alternatives haven't we considered yet, even unlikely ones?

SAY THIS

FRAME We'll look at this one hat at a time. Right now we're all wearing the same hat, so we all think in the same direction together.

NUDGE If people slip into debate, name it: that's a Black Hat point; let's park it and come back when we put that hat on.

LAND We've worn every hat. Blue Hat time: let's pull the threads together and decide what we do next.

TIPS & WATCH-OUTS

- Have the whole group wear one hat at a time rather than assigning hats to individuals; parallel thinking is the point.
- Keep Red Hat quick and unjustified; feelings get stated, not defended, then you move on.

- If one perspective dominates, that's usually a stuck hat; deliberately call the Green or Yellow Hat to rebalance.

FOR PARTICIPANTS

DURING

- **White Hat.** Share facts and figures; avoid opinions and emotions.
- **Red Hat.** Express emotions and gut reactions without justification.
- **Black Hat.** Identify risks and drawbacks; evaluate ideas critically.
- **Yellow Hat.** Highlight benefits and opportunities; explore optimistic scenarios.
- **Green Hat.** Generate creative ideas and unconventional solutions.
- **Blue Hat.** Facilitate the process, manage time, and guide transitions.

PAIRS WELL WITH

Mind Map SWOT Analysis Weighted Decision Matrix

- **Mind Map.** Capture Green Hat ideas on a Mind Map so the group can see how the alternatives branch and connect.
- **SWOT Analysis.** Feed the White, Yellow, and Black Hat rounds into a SWOT to organize facts, benefits, and risks into one view.
- **Weighted Decision Matrix.** When the hats have produced several options, score them against agreed criteria in a Weighted Decision Matrix during the Blue Hat close.

SUPPORTING TECH

- **Virtual Collaboration Tools (e.g., Zoom, Microsoft Teams).** Host online discussions with the whole group in the main room for each hat; use breakout rooms only when small groups work the same hat in parallel.
- **Mind Mapping Software (e.g., MindMeister, XMind).** Participants can visually map out ideas generated during the Green Hat session, creating a structured representation of their creative solutions.

RUN IT ONLINE

- **Show the Current Hat.** Put the active hat's color, name, and one-line description at the top of a shared slide or a Miro or FigJam board, and change it visibly at every transition.

- **One Column per Hat.** Build a board with six columns and have everyone add notes only to the current hat's column, silently for three minutes, before discussing. Keep each hat to about ten minutes online, with a short break after the third.
- **Run Red Hat as a Chat Waterfall.** Ask everyone to type one gut reaction in the chat and press enter at the same moment. It keeps the Red Hat fast, unjustified, and free of anchoring.
- **Hybrid.** Have in-room and remote participants work on the same digital board, show the current hat on the room screen, and take the first contribution under each hat from someone remote.

IN PRACTICE • HUMANITARIAN

Improving Emergency Shelter Design for Disaster Relief

An emergency shelter team of engineers, field staff, and community liaisons had to decide whether to change its shelter design before the next procurement. The facilitator opened in Blue Hat, naming the question and the order of the hats. White Hat set out the facts on the current shelters: size, materials, and cost. Red Hat surfaced residents' worries about heat and privacy. Black Hat found poor ventilation and weak joints, and Yellow Hat credited fast assembly and low cost. Green Hat produced two changes: a raised vent and a modular partition. In the closing Blue Hat, the team agreed to fit both changes to a small batch of shelters and have field staff report back after a month, before the next order was placed.

IN PRACTICE • CORPORATE

Bid or No-Bid on a Hospital Extension

To decide whether a construction firm should bid on a hospital project far larger than any it had won.

A mid-sized construction firm's bid team, nine people from estimating, operations, safety, and finance, had ten days to decide whether to bid on a regional hospital extension three times larger than any job it had won. The first meeting split into enthusiasts and skeptics arguing past each other. The bid director reran the discussion as a ninety-minute Six Thinking Hats session, with the whole team wearing one hat at a time. White Hat exposed a gap no one had flagged: the firm had no in-house experience with medical gas systems. Red Hat was short and revealing; the operations lead admitted his worry was staffing, not money. Green Hat produced the idea of a joint bid with a specialist mechanical contractor.

The team bid jointly, and the skeptics signed off because their concerns had shaped the plan.

[Contents](#)

 Goode Design & Consulting

Quick-Reference Matrix

All 72 methods at a glance, grouped by category. Tap a name to open its full entry. Times are typical for a group of eight to twenty; online, allow a little more. Every method can run in person, online, or hybrid. Risk is social exposure: Low means nobody is singled out; High means people judge, or are judged, in public.

GS Goal Setting & Clarification

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
\$100	30 min	4-20	MEDIUM	A creative exercise where participants allocate a hypothetical \$100 budget across program or project components.
GROW	30 min 1:1; 60-75 min in triads	1:1, or 6-24 in triads	LOW	GROW is a coaching and goal-setting framework for personal and professional development.
Hypothesis	45-60 min	4-20	MEDIUM	The Hypothesis method has participants form educated guesses about solutions or outcomes and test them.
Newspaper Headline	30 min	4-30	MEDIUM	The Newspaper Headline method has participants capture a program or project's desired

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
				outcomes as compelling headlines.
OKRs (Objectives and Key Results)	1-2 hr	4-15	MEDIUM	Sets clear, measurable objectives and key results; reach for it to align a team's efforts with organizational goals and track progress.
Peer Reviews	1-2 hr	4-20	HIGH	Peers assess and give feedback on each other's work or ideas.
Roles & Responsibilities	30-45 min	4-15	MEDIUM	Roles and responsibilities clarify each person's or team's functions and duties within a project or program.
Sailboat	45-60 min	4-15	MEDIUM	The Sailboat metaphor explores goals, obstacles, and strategies in a visually engaging way.
Skills Market	30-60 min	12-60	MEDIUM	A structured marketplace where participants profile their skills and expertise, then circulate to find

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
				complementary strengths and collaboration opportunities.
SMART Goals	15-30 min	2-20	LOW	SMART Goals is a method for setting clear, achievable objectives that are Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound.
Stakeholder Map	30-60 min	4-15	MEDIUM	A visual mapping activity where participants plot stakeholders by interest and influence; reach for it before work begins to build a shared picture of the project landscape and an engagement strategy.
SWOT Analysis	60-90 min	4-12	MEDIUM	A strategic planning method that evaluates a project's Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, and Threats; reach for it to weigh internal and external factors before committing to a goal.

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
Value Proposition	1-2 hr	4-24	MEDIUM	The Value Proposition method defines and communicates the unique value a product, service, or solution offers its target audience.
Vision Board	1-2 hr	4-30	LOW	A visual collage of images, words, and symbols that represents goals and aspirations; reach for it to make desired outcomes tangible and motivating.

IG Idea Generation

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
Affinity Mapping	45-90 min	5-25	LOW	A silent-sorting method that groups many individual ideas or observations into themes, so a group can make sense of a lot of input fast.
Brainwriting	20-45 min	4-30	LOW	Brainwriting is a silent brainstorming technique where participants write ideas individually and then build on each other's ideas by passing sheets in a structured rotation.
Crazy Eights	30 min	3-10	MEDIUM	A fast-paced ideation exercise that generates many creative ideas quickly; reach for it to push a group past obvious solutions early in a design process.
Design Dash	2-3 hr	8-30	MEDIUM	Design Dash is a fast-paced ideation and prototyping exercise for quickly developing and testing new solutions.
Heart Head Hand	15-30 min	6-30	LOW	A reflective activity that helps participants connect with a topic or experience emotionally (Heart), intellectually (Head), and through action (Hand).

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
Idea Storm	1-2 hr	8-40	MEDIUM	Idea Storm is an ideation technique that generates and refines many ideas through group collaboration: alone first, then in small groups, then with the whole room.
Idea Web	30 min	4-15	LOW	Idea Web is a visual brainstorming tool that helps participants generate and organize ideas and connections around a topic or problem.
Lotus Blossom Technique	45-60 min	1-12	LOW	The Lotus Blossom Technique is a creative brainstorming method that expands a central idea into related concepts using a structured grid of "petals."
Mind Map	30-45 min	3-12	LOW	Mind Mapping is a visual brainstorming technique to organize, explore, and connect ideas around a central topic.
Reverse Brainstorming	30-45 min	4-20	LOW	A technique for identifying potential problems or obstacles related to a topic or challenge by asking how to cause the problem instead of how to solve it.
Round Robin	30 min	5-12	MEDIUM	Round Robin generates ideas by going around the group, one person and one idea at a time, so that participation is equal by design.
SCAMPER Technique	1.5-2 hr	6-30	LOW	A creative thinking process that prompts lateral rethinking of existing problems and solutions; reach for it to generate new options from a concept you already have.
Storyboarding	60 min	3-20	MEDIUM	Storyboarding plans and outlines events, processes, or ideas visually, as a sequence of captioned frames.

PS Problem Solving

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
Appreciative Inquiry (AI)	Multi-day	10-100+	MEDIUM	Appreciative Inquiry is a strengths-based approach to organizational development and problem-solving that starts from what is already working rather than from what is broken.
Assumption Map	20-30 min	3-12	MEDIUM	The Assumption Map method surfaces and challenges the assumptions that shape a group's decisions and problem-solving, so the group can see what it is taking for granted before it commits.
Barrier Analysis	Multi-day	4-12	LOW	Barrier Analysis identifies the obstacles that prevent people from adopting a desired behavior or reaching a

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
				desired outcome.
Blind Vote	15-30 min	5-50	LOW	An anonymous voting technique for making impartial group decisions; reach for it when personal bias or social pressure could skew an open vote.
Fishbone Diagram (Ishikawa Diagram)	1-2 hr	4-12	MEDIUM	The Fishbone Diagram is a visual tool for identifying and categorizing potential causes of a problem to find its root causes.
Five Whys	60-90 min	3-10	HIGH	The Five Whys identifies the root cause of an issue by asking "why" repeatedly, with each answer becoming the subject of the next question.
Hypothetical Scenario Analysis	Half day	6-20	LOW	Hypothetical Scenario Analysis is a strategic decision-making method for exploring the potential outcomes of decisions across hypothetical situations.
Impact Effort Map	20-30 min	4-12	MEDIUM	The Impact Effort Map helps participants weigh each task's potential impact against the effort it requires, so the group can see which work to do first.
Mindful Problem Solving	45 min	4-20	LOW	Mindful Problem Solving combines mindfulness practices with problem-solving techniques to boost focus, creativity, and emotional regulation.
Pareto Analysis	1-5 hr	4-12	LOW	Based on the 80/20 principle, Pareto Analysis identifies and prioritizes the few factors that contribute most to a problem.
Pre-mortem	45-60 min	6-20	MEDIUM	A planning check in which a team imagines that its project has already failed and works backward to explain why, surfacing the risks that optimism and politeness usually keep quiet.
Priority Map	20-30 min	3-12	MEDIUM	Priority mapping helps participants determine the relative importance and urgency of tasks, items, or goals by placing them on a shared grid.
Problem Statement	1-2 hr	4-12	LOW	The Problem Statement method defines and articulates, in one or two agreed sentences, a specific problem or challenge to address.
Starbursting	45 min	4-15	LOW	Starbursting is a brainstorming technique that explores a problem or idea by asking who, what, where, when, why, and how.

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
Three Little Pigs	45-60 min	6-30	MEDIUM	The Three Little Pigs method is a storytelling and problem-solving exercise in which participants analyze situations, make decisions, and weigh the consequences of their choices.
Who What When	30 min	4-15	MEDIUM	Who What When is a planning tool that defines the stakeholders, actions, and timelines a project needs, so every action leaves the room with an owner and a date.

SP Strategic Planning

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
Critical Path Method (CPM)	1.5-2 hr	4-12	LOW	A project management technique that identifies the sequence of tasks critical to completion; reach for it to find the shortest possible timeline and the tasks that cannot slip.
Design Thinking	Half day	6-30	MEDIUM	A human-centered, five-stage process (empathize, define, ideate, prototype, test) in which a multidisciplinary team solves a problem by understanding the people who have it, reframing the problem, and testing rough solutions with real users before committing to one.
Gantt Chart	1-2 hr	3-12	LOW	A planning session in which the team builds its project timeline together on a wall, as a Gantt chart, so dependencies and clashes are argued out in the room instead of discovered later.
RACI Chart	60-90 min	4-12	MEDIUM	A RACI chart is a project management tool that clarifies team roles by naming, for every task or decision, who is Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, and Informed.

DM Decision Making

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
Cost-Benefit Analysis	1-2 hr	4-12	LOW	A method that evaluates the outcomes and financial implications of different options by putting costs and benefits in the same units, usually money, so their net value can be compared side by side.
Decision Auction	45 min	6-20	MEDIUM	A decision-making method where participants bid on options by perceived value; reach for it to prioritize competing choices and allocate limited resources.

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
Delphi Method	Ongoing	8-30	LOW	The Delphi Method is a structured, iterative process for reaching consensus on a topic among a group of experts.
Eisenhower Matrix	30 min	6-30	MEDIUM	The Eisenhower Matrix is a prioritization tool that sorts tasks by urgency and importance into four quadrants, each with its own action: do it now, schedule it, delegate it, or drop it.
Nominal Group Technique (NGT)	1.5-2 hr	5-12	MEDIUM	A structured method for generating and ranking ideas in which everyone writes silently, shares in turn, and ranks privately, so every participant has an equal voice.
Paired Comparison Analysis	30 min	3-10	LOW	Paired Comparison Analysis determines the relative importance or priority of multiple options or criteria by comparing them two at a time.
Q&A Panel Discussion	60 min	20-200	LOW	A Q&A panel discussion lets participants engage subject-matter experts on a specific topic through targeted questions.
Rank Order Voting	45 min	5-50	LOW	Rank Order Voting prioritizes options by having participants rank them in order of preference.
Weighted Decision Matrix	60-90 min	4-12	MEDIUM	The Weighted Decision Matrix evaluates options by scoring them against weighted criteria for a systematic decision.

RF Reflection & Feedback

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
360-Degree Feedback	1-2 hr	1:1	HIGH	360-Degree Feedback gathers input from supervisors, peers, subordinates, and self-assessment for a comprehensive view of a person's skills, behaviors, and performance.
4Ls Retrospective	30-60 min	4-20	LOW	A retrospective in which participants look back on a project, sprint, workshop, or program through four prompts: what they Liked, Learned, Lacked, and Longed For.
After Action Review	30-60 min	4-20	MEDIUM	A structured, blameless debrief, held soon after an event, in which the people who did the work compare what was supposed to happen with what actually happened and decide what to sustain or improve next time.
Feedback Forms	10-15 min	5-100+	LOW	A short closing round, designed into the session, in which participants rate and comment on what just happened, on

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
				paper, by phone, or aloud, in a way that makes honest answers easy.
Feedback Loops	Ongoing	Whole team	LOW	Feedback Loops are systematic processes that continuously gather stakeholder feedback to drive ongoing assessment and improvement.
Mad Sad Glad	15-20 min	4-15	MEDIUM	A reflection and feedback exercise where participants sort their feelings into mad, sad, and glad; reach for it in a retrospective to surface honest emotional feedback.
Plus-Delta	15-20 min	5-40	LOW	Plus-Delta is a feedback and reflection exercise for evaluating a learning experience, project, or program.
Reflection Journals	Ongoing	6-30	LOW	Short, prompted journal entries that participants in a multi-session program write between sessions, to notice how their thinking and practice change over time.
Reflection Sprints	15-25 min	3-30	LOW	Time-limited, focused sessions where participants critically reflect on a topic, experience, or learning outcome.
Stop Start Continue	20-90 min	4-30	LOW	The Stop Start Continue method supports continuous improvement by asking what a group should stop doing, start doing, and continue doing, so feedback ends in specific changes.
Think-Pair-Share	10-20 min	6-60	LOW	Think-Pair-Share is a collaborative strategy that builds engagement and critical thinking through individual reflection, paired discussion, and group sharing.

UP Uncovering Perspectives & Expertise

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
Democratic Discussion	30-60 min	6-15	MEDIUM	Democratic Discussion promotes inclusive, equitable participation in group discussions.
Fishbowl	30-60 min	12-50	HIGH	A structured discussion format in which a small inner circle talks while a larger outer circle listens, with seats rotating so observers can step in.
Six Thinking Hats	1-2 hr	4-12	MEDIUM	A technique for group and individual thinking that examines a problem from six distinct perspectives.

METHOD	TIME	GROUP	RISK	WHAT IT'S FOR
Socratic Questioning	10-15 min	4-15	HIGH	Socratic Questioning stimulates critical thinking, encouraging participants to explore ideas, uncover assumptions, and reach logical conclusions.
World Café	2-3 hr	12-100+	LOW	The World Café facilitates large-group dialogue in an environment resembling a café.

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